Summative solo performance assignment for the Department of Music

This is a three-part assignment for the first year 'Solo Performance' module. The first two parts are self-reflective – the first on the student's proposed recital programme, the second on their participation in performance ensembles. The third part consists of three concert reviews for a newspaper readership.

MARKER COMMENT

Your goal as a writer is to make what you have to say as clear to your audience (most often the assignment markers) as possible. You can do this by paying attention to two broad categories: content and technique. Content is what the essay *says.* Technique is *how it says it*. This essay earned a high mark because it excels in both categories.

Content:

For this assignment, students were provided guidance templates that told them how to structure their writing and what information was required. This essay sticks closely to the template, providing all the requested information in the order it was requested. The reflective writing assignments were designed to help the author connect their activities on the course to their overall development as a musician this year and in the long-term. The reflections in this submission clearly connect learning activities to musical development by using concrete examples. The author also demonstrates that they thought deeply and systematically about how to overcome challenges. This can be seen, for example, in the third paragraph of Reflection on Ensemble Participation.

Technique:

While most essays have good-to-excellent content, that content is often obscured by poor writing technique. Poor writing is akin to whispering: if you do so, your audience will have trouble understanding your brilliant ideas and your mark will suffer. This submission demonstrates a high level of technical writing. On the document level, it is formatted cleanly a free from typos (grammar and spelling). At paragraph level, each paragraph contains one primary idea that is clearly stated in the opening sentence, and then elaborated on. Drilling down further, each sentence is short and contains a single idea. This makes it easy for the reader to understand on a first reading.

The takeaway from this well-written example should be that you should always make it as easy as possible for your audience (i.e., those marking your work) to understand your writing. You can do this by, first, providing all the information asked for in the assignment brief and, second, by ensuring your writing is clear, concise, and free from typos.

Programme Rationale

CEDAS COMMENTS

In the coming year, the biggest objective my teacher and I have decided to aim for is to create a better quality of sound by enhancing my projection through a more stabilised bow technique. This overarching aim will involve re-examining my bow hold and practicing moving up and down the strings, paying attention to bow pressure, speed and placement. I aim to improve my bowing by beginning my practice sessions with a series of 'bow games', designed to help improve flexibility in finger and wrist movements. Paying more attention to my right hand will inevitably shine more light on my sound quality and make my performance on the violin more engaging.

Clear statement of objectives.

In response to this objective, I have chosen to study Mozart's *Adagio in E major* and to perform this piece for my first term recital. I chose this piece because its beauty is created through the result of a controlled bow technique and serene sound quality. This will give me the opportunity to put my bowing practice into context and still develop a more stabilised bow technique whilst exploring the Classical style and repertoire. With a fondness for the Romantic era, I plan to perform Brahms *Sonatensatz* in the second term. I have a great ability to indulge in vibrato and my own musicality when performing this kind of music, and whilst the Mozart piece will encourage me to retain and control these aspects, Brahms will allow me to use these strengths to my advantage. Improving my bowing technique will also expose my left-hand activity making intonation more obvious, presenting another challenge to my playing. The demanding notation of *Sonatensatz* will give my left-hand the opportunity to practice more ambitious shifts and fingerings, familiarising myself more with the fingerboard. I also plan on studying the first movement of Lalo's *Symphonie espagnole* which I will focus on over the summer. The ambitiousness and virtuosity of this piece will open up challenges involving speed which I will have to approach slowly. Practicing fast passages using different rhythms and, of course, a metronome will help me familiarise myself with the 'speeding up technique' and enable me to develop a fast way of increasing pace in music.

Outline relating practice activities on specific musical pieces to objectives.

I have got into the habit of doing bow exercises for ten minutes at the beginning of each practice session, proceeding with studies from Kreutzer's *Forty-two Studies or Caprices for Violin* (vol. 230). These studies are not designed to be played musically and primarily focus on strengthening bow technique. So far, they have helped improve my quality of sound significantly and I intend to keep working through this book over the year to progress further. Additionally, I am pleased with how these studies are having an effect on the Mozart I am learning and the overall sound that I am producing. It was made clear to me that developing sound quality does not happen overnight. However, my teacher has mentioned that there is already a significant difference in the sound that I am now producing after only a few weeks of lessons! Over the coming weeks, I aim to broaden my understanding of the Classical style and interpret features such as phrasing

Assessment of progress on practice activities.

in the way that they were intended. Mirroring style and period is something I find challenging, particularly with Classical music and I aim to tackle this through putting an emphasis on elegance in the short, well-balanced melodies that appear frequently in this kind of repertoire.

One of the recordings of Mozart's *Adagio in E major* that I have found helpful to watch is Maxim Vengerov's recording, *Vengerov – Mozart – Adagio in E major.* In this visual recording, I particularly like the amount of movement Vengerov uses to express his performance. He moves with the music as the bow strokes the strings but not in a way that distorts the performance, making it an evenly balanced mixture where the sound quality is obtained throughout. Additionally, I paid close attention to the fingerings Vengerov used and took note of what he did in some areas of the piece that required more challenging shifts, such as in the chromatic bars in the second section. Applying some of these to my own performance have aided areas of intonation that I had encountered previously in the more technically challenging areas of the piece. As well as this, I have also found watching Hilary Hahn's *100 Days of Practice* series inspiring. In this collection of videos, it was encouraging to see that even a great violinist, likeHahn, spends time working on basic finger placement patterns and double-stop motions, before moving onto repertoire.

Discussion of how other musicians have inspired and informed student's own development.

This is an important aspect of reflective writing – making links with other practice.

Overall, this term I have been pleased with how I have settled into these new practice strategies. I believe each piece I have chosen to study this year will bring its own challenges, giving me the opportunity to practice a range techniques and methods of performing. In preparation for the upcoming term, I plan to buy the music for Brahms *Sonatensatz* and begin learning this over the holiday break. I plan to continue practicing bow techniques in order to give my violin a larger voice that will improve my quality of sound in the long run.

Reflection on Ensemble Participation

During this term, I have been involved with the Royal Holloway Symphony Orchestra, directed by Rebecca Miller. The Orchestra rehearses Wednesday evenings in The Boiler House Auditorium, and we have been preparing for our first concert of the year as part of The International Concert Series.

Skills I have been developing throughout this term have had much to do with leadership and organisation. As the primary second violinist with an Orchestral Scholarship, I have taken on a leading role sitting at the front of the section, representing this part of the Orchestra. Discovering throughout the term how important this role is, I have been working on

Notice how the writer makes repeated use of first person 'I'. Notice too that this does not mean the writing is informal – it maintains the formality and precision of 'conventional' essay writing.

enhancing my communication skills with the rest of the section by making bigger gestures with my violin and by passing back bowing suggestions during and after rehearsal. As a leader it is my responsibility to be at each rehearsal, ready with all the correct music and bowings at hand. Due to the pandemic, masks, stands and covid tests became mandatory which was hard to remember at first, but after several weeks, this became more of a routine. Aiming to practice Orchestral repertoire a couple of times each week has helped me feel more prepared for rehearsals, where I need to be performing to the best of my ability in order to lead my section.

One of the hurdles I have come across in Orchestra is that I have sometimes found it challenging to speak up to people outside of my section, particularly in string sectionals and scholar-lead rehearsals. Identifying problematic passages in the music through my own individual practice and by listening to surrounding string instruments in rehearsal would give me the chance to contribute more in sectionals by suggesting things to go over.

Each paragraph sticks to a point, which is introduced by a clearly expressed topic sentence.

Overall, this term has allowed me to form a good foundation of skills that I will seek to develop throughout the year. I also plan to improve my sightreading in preparation for the new repertoire that will be introduced in the second term.

Concert Review 1

Sunday 24th October 2021, 3:00pm
Southbank Centre's Royal Festival Hall
Faure Requiem Music for Reflection and Hope
The Bach Choir and The Philharmonia Orchestra conducted by David Hill
Katy Hill - Soprano soloist
Gareth Brynmor John - Baritone soloist
Zsolt- Tihamer Visontay - Violin soloist

Programme

GABRIEL JACKSON The Promise (commissioned by The Bach Choir; world premiere)
RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS Fantasia on a Theme by Thomas Tallis
RICHARD BLACKFORD Vision of a Garden (commissioned by The Bach Choir; world premier)

Interval

GABRIEL FAURÉ Cantique de Jean Racine
GABRIEL FAURÉ Requiem

For the first time after twenty months of lockdown, The Bach Choir returned to the concert platform with a moving performance, featuring two of Faure's best-loved choral works with the Philharmonia Orchestra. *Fauré's Requiem* was paired with two world premieres commissioned by The Bach Choir during the pandemic, creating a restful programme of music, allowing the audience to reflect over the past year and have hope for a brighter future.

A scene-setting introduction that gives a succinct account of key background for this performance.

The concert began with the first world premiere, *The Promise*, by Gabriel Jackson which was an emotive, unaccompanied work presented alongside a powerful short film. This emotional performance became more so as Jackson arose from the audience to express his gratitude to conductor, David Hill, and The Bach Choir, while applause radiated throughout the hall.

The writer demonstrates an eye for the telling detail, making this review engaging.

Each piece was introduced by presenter, Anna Lapwood, who gave special credits to Ivor Novello award-winner, Richard Blackford, before premiering his *Vision of a Garden*. This set a poignant text by choir member, Peter Johnstone, that incorporated extracts from diaries written for Peter by NHS nurses during his many weeks on a ventilator to battle COVID. Despite the slightly prolonged intermission between that and the previous piece, this was moving to hear and high praise was given to the NHS workers in the audience for their life-saving sacrifices to COVID patients.

This combines an informed appreciation of the technical aspects of the performance with the kind of vivid language that engages a newspaper audience e.g., adjectives such as *serene, soaring, shimmer*

Soprano and Baritone soloists Katy Hill and Gareth Brynmor John joined The Bach Choir in *Fauré's Requiem* in the second half. This beautiful performance echoed around the hall through the choir's serene harmonic movement and graceful melodic lines. Katy Hill's *Pie Jesu* solo soared over the orchestra, her projection and tone successfully captivating the beauty of this movement. Zsolt- Tihamer Visontay's violin solo in *Sanctus* weaved through the movement without fault. His impeccable vibrato made the top octave shimmer at the end of the movement before fading out on a delicate trill.

This was a well-loved performance and The Bach Choir and Philharmonic did not disappoint with their reflective performance bringing the audience hope for a post-pandemic future.

Concert Review 2

Thursday 4th November 2021, 7:30pm
Royal Holloway University of London Picture Gallery
Berendina Cook and Michael Stanley Piano Duo Concert in Aid of the Brain Tumour Charity, Concert series 2021-22
Berendina Cook – Piano (Lower Register)
Michael Stanley – Piano (Upper Register)

Programme

J.C.F. BACH Sonata in C Major
Allegro con brio
Andante
Rondo
BRAHMS Hungarian Dances Nos: 1,2 & 5
MENDELSSOHN Andante and Allegro assai vivace

Interval

YORK BOWEN Three Pieces
Allegro
Barcarolle
Moto Perpetuo
BRIDGE Two English Folksongs
Sally in our Alley
Cherry Ripe
GERSHWIN An American in Paris

From the beautiful environment of the Royal Holloway Picture Gallery, Berendina Cook and Michael Stanley came together to perform an exciting selection of piano duets in aid of The Brain Tumour Charity. They formed their duo in 1984, after graduating from Royal Holloway, University of London, and have established themselves as one of Britain's leading specialists of the duet partnership.

Again, the scene is set in a concise way providing key background information as well as a sense of the performance space.

The concert began with a Sonata by J.C.F. Bach. Their enthusiasm for each piece was matched by their unique approach to their work which included introducing the background to the music and illustrating aspects of the duet before performing. Cook mentioned beforehand how they had never performed this piece to an audience before, but, this did not seem to hinder the lively and elegant character that jumped out of the music as they escalated into the winding semiquaver passages.

A very inviting style that engages a lay reader while at the same time demonstrating a musician's insight.

The romance in Brahms *Hungarian Dance no.1* was captured immediately through Stanley's beautiful descending arpeggios in the top register of the piano. Cook highlighted how this piece was perhaps about Brahms's love for Clara Schumann, and this idea could be seen through the intense dynamic contrasts of her bass line and movement with the music.

The duo's partnership was strong throughout the concert but could not have been more so than in Mendelssohn's *Andante and Allegro assai vivace*. With the regular crossing of hands and addition of fireworks going off outside, their concentration couldn't have been more intense. This small interference proved to be amusing to both pianists and the audience but in no way was the performance diminished.

The writer picks out a moment in the performance to explore. It makes the reader feel that they are present at the concert.

The concert ended with a heartfelt performance of Gershwin's *An American in Paris*. In relation to the charity that they were supporting, Cook mentioned how Gershwin passed away due to a brain tumour like her son. She raised awareness of how the circumstances of saving people's lives from brain tumours was not great, and how thankful she was for all the donations received. A rapturous applause echoed the gallery after this emotional performance.

There is no doubt that this was an enjoyable evening for the audience, full of exciting repertoire and entertainment, all for a good cause.

Concert Review 3

Sunday 7th November 2021, 7:30pm
Southbank Centre's Royal Festival Hall
Hilary Hahn: The Lark Ascending, Human / Nature: Music for a Precious Planet
The Philharmonia Orchestra conducted by Elim Chan
Hilary Hahn – Violin

Programme

VAUGHAN WILLIAMS The Lark Ascending
GABRIELLA SMITH Tumblebird Contrails
PROKOFIEV Violin Concerto No.1

Interval

BRAHMS Symphony No.2

Through the exploration of humanity's relationship with nature, three-time GRAMMY Award-winning violinist Hilary Hahn took to the stage with The Philharmonia Orchestra for an evening of music dedicated to our precious planet. Through the music of Vaughan Williams, this event emphasised the role music can play in a world that is under threat from the actions and choices of humans themselves, shining light on the major issues of our time.

Every note was filled with tenderness and beauty as Hahn embraced the soaring motifs of *The Lark Ascending*. Her top register notes glistened as they faded into silence and her tonal quality echoed throughout the hall. Hahn's violin becoming both the lark's song and its flight. The image of this lone bird swooping above rolling hills and serene solitude was effectively portrayed through Hahn's expressive movement, capturing its grace with the orchestra acting as the landscape the lark freely soared through. A rapturous applause filled the hall after this phenomenal performance. Hahn showed her appreciation to the audience and the Philharmonia as she received a rose bouquet, handing one to the conductor, Elim Chan, symbolising her gratitude.

This paragraph successfully combines:

a. A journalistic style that engages with metaphor (*swooping birds*) and adjectives (*glistened*) but stops short of being over-the-top. The language is broadsheet, not tabloid.
b. Technical insight (*motifs, top register*)
c. A strong evocation of place and audience.

Immediately after this performance, the audience was taken to the beautiful beaches of Point Reyes in California through Gabriella Smith's *Tumblebird Contrails*. This piece was a vivid reminder of just how varied a composer's interaction with nature can be. The nineteenth-century Romantic ideal of heavenly nature is here replaced with a soundscape that seeks to draw attention to the fragility of the natural world in the twentieth-century, and to provide listeners with an emotional connection to the natural world in a plea for action. This was heard through the hallucinatory sounds of the Pacific imitated by the clarinettists blowing softly into their reeds, whilst the string players scraped at their strings to conjure the sounds of crashing waves and the wind.

The concert ended with a heart-felt performance of Brahms's *Second Symphony*. Elim Chan's enthusiasm in each beat brought life into the music as she sailed the orchestra through the four movements. This performance was a huge success that brought tears to her eyes as the audience cheered whilst she showed her appreciation to the Philharmonic for a fantastic evening.

Overall, this was an enjoyable concert where humanity's relationship with nature was explored through the help of Hilary Hahn's outstanding performing ability and the deep love of nature composers, such as Vaughn Williams, expressed through their music.

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